

Publishing on a social network

People can judge the content that their connections publish to social media by liking or sharing it. If the content a user publishes is perceived by others to have value, their reputation increases and they become a valuable resource for others. Viewed through this lens, social media is like a popularity contest.



Being “super-me” △

People tend to create a “super-me”, or someone that’s a little bit better than they are when publishing on social media. They might share their best holiday snaps, or the fancy food they have eaten. Their posts may not fully reflect reality, though.



◁ Public vs private chat

Studies show that two people who communicate via private message are more likely to be closer than people who only communicate via public “walls”. That said, some people prefer public chatting as everyone connected can see it.

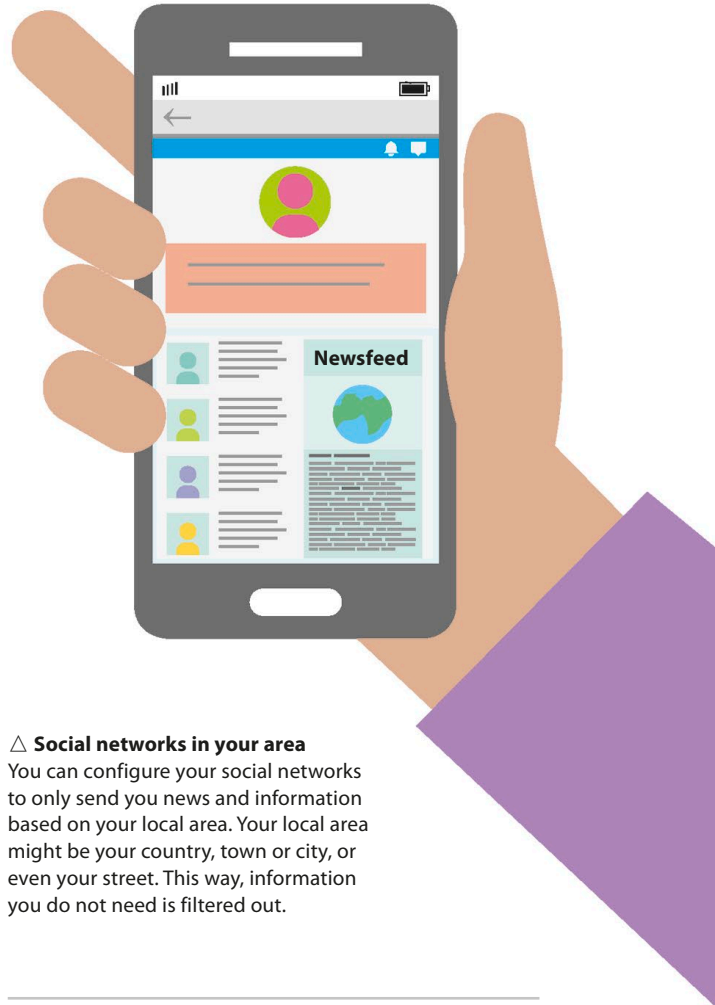
IN DEPTH

Comparing ourselves

Some people use the content they see on social media – whether it has been created by family or friends, sportspeople, movie stars, or other celebrities – to reflect negatively on their own lives. It is worth remembering that social media users present an edited version of their lives to the network, and that it isn’t real life, but just what someone wants you to see.

Social networks and news

One of the primary uses of social networks is sharing news stories among friends and connections. Social network connections are likely to be interested in the same things as one another, and so sharing news stories is an easy way of sharing information that might be useful to a network. News and other media organizations learned this quickly, and became active members of these networks, creating content that would be easily shareable on these platforms.



△ Social networks in your area

You can configure your social networks to only send you news and information based on your local area. Your local area might be your country, town or city, or even your street. This way, information you do not need is filtered out.

“Social media [is] not only sharing the news, but driving it.”

Dan Rather (b. 1931), American journalist